

Discover and Build On Research with OSF Search

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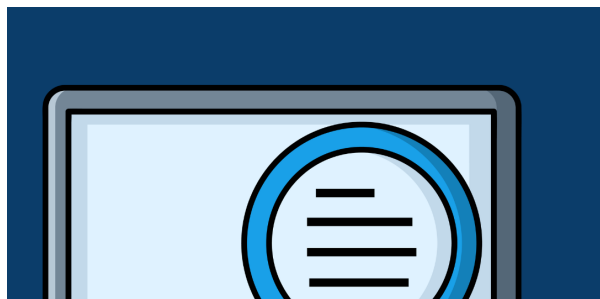
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Monthly Tips and Tricks

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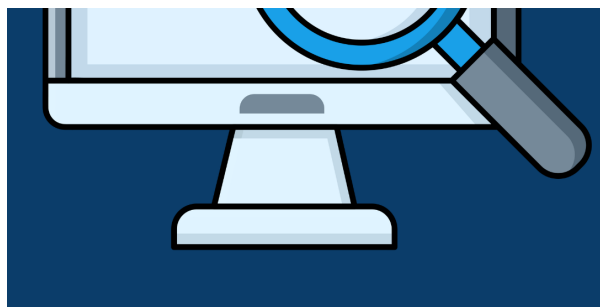
OSF supports research across its entire lifecycle—from planning and preregistration through data, analysis, and publication. That also makes it a powerful place to discover open research outputs, with a wealth of connected, citable work available to explore and build upon. In this newsletter, we're sharing a guide to getting the most out of OSF Search.

[Explore OSF Search](#)



How OSF Search Works

OSF Search is built on **metadata**—the structured information that describes a research object, like its title, contributors, subjects, and license. Unlike Google,



which indexes all the words on a page, OSF Search only indexes these metadata fields and not the full text of uploaded files.

This means that if a preregistration or preprint doesn't have robust metadata, it may not surface in results. It also means that adding good metadata to your own work is just as important for discoverability as the search techniques you use.

Want to learn more about metadata? [Register for this month's OSF Essentials webinar, How to Use FAIR Metadata.](#)

Use Tabs and Filters to Narrow Your Results

OSF Search is available from the left sidebar on any OSF page, or by navigating to osf.io/search. There, you'll see a randomly selected sample of public content from across the platform. You can start browsing right away, or use the tabs to filter by content type: registrations, preprints, files, and users. Filters narrow results further within each type, using controlled terms like subject area, license, institution, and funder.

There are a few OSF-specific filters worth knowing about. For registrations, you can filter by whether linked data, code, or a published paper has been attached. This is a quick way to find registrations with associated outputs already linked. You can also filter by registration template, which is useful if you're looking for a specific study type such as a systematic review.

Search Smarter with Operators

OSF Search returns results based on how frequently your search terms appear in a record's metadata relative to the length of that record. For instance, a term that appears 10 times in a short description ranks higher than one that appears 25 times in a very long one.

By default, keyword searches also find close matches—e.g., searching for *health* may also return results for *healthy*. This is useful for casting a wide net, but can bring in irrelevant results. OSF Search supports a set of special characters to make more precise queries, functioning similarly to Boolean operators used in other databases, with a few OSF-specific

additions. Below is a quick reference guide.

Refining Your Results

- **" " Phrase search:** Put terms in quotation marks to find a specific phrase—e.g., *"maternal depression"* returns only results containing that exact phrase, while *maternal depression* without quotes shows results where both words appear anywhere in the metadata.
- **+ AND:** Requires both terms to be present. This is the default behavior, so *research reproducibility* and *research + reproducibility* return identical results.
- **- NOT:** Excludes results containing a term, e.g. *video game -child*.

Broadening or Combining Your Search

- **| OR:** Returns results where either term is present. Useful when a concept has multiple names, e.g. *maternal | paternal*.
- *** Prefix:** At the end of a term, searches for words beginning with that string. *pos** returns results for *positive*, *possible*, *post*, and so on.
- **~ Fuzzy:** Enables broader matching for variant spellings or typos, e.g. *colour~1* returns results containing both *colour* and *color*.
- **() Grouping:** Groups and combines multiple concepts, e.g. *("climate change" | "global warming") "systematic review"* returns results containing either phrase alongside *"systematic review"*.

Note: If you need to use a special character literally—for instance, *B+ blood type*—add a backslash before the character: *B\+ blood type*.

Learn More: OSF Search help guide

Keep a Record of Your Search Strategy

Write down the search terms, operators, and filters you've used, or simply copy the URL from your results page. This captures your full search query and can be saved and returned to later.

Make Your Work Findable, Too

Discoverability works both ways: if your OSF content is missing a title, description, tags, or subject terms, others may not be able to readily find it. Metadata is an opportunity to

describe the meaning, context, and importance of your work to others.

Adding robust metadata increases the discoverability and usability of your work on the OSF.

[Learn more about metadata on the OSF.](#)

See OSF Search in Action

Check out the recording of our recent webinar for a deep dive into OSF Search, or visit our help guide for a detailed walkthrough.

Watch Recording: How to Use
OSF Search

Help Guide: Getting Started with
OSF Search

Self-Led Training Courses

We recently launched the **Open Scholarship Training for Researchers Series**, offering online courses you can complete at your own pace.

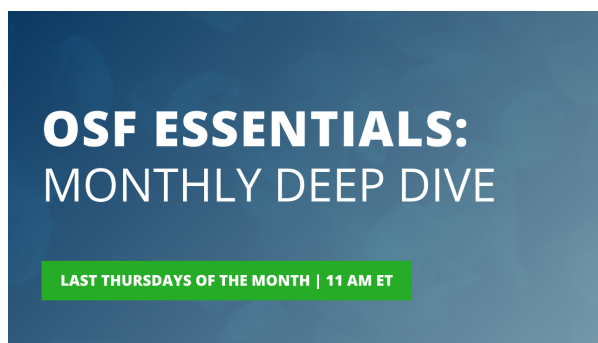
A great place to start is our introductory course, [Fundamentals of Open Scholarship](#), where you'll receive structured learning, assessment, and a verified digital badge that you can share on your CV, LinkedIn, and email signature.

The series also includes Preregistration and Registered Reports, with additional courses coming soon on data sharing, reproducible methods, preprints, and more.



[View the Course Catalog](#)

Upcoming Webinars



OSF Essentials: Monthly Deep Dive

Last Thursdays of the month at 11 AM ET

This monthly series teaches researchers how to use the OSF to carry out key tasks in their workflows. Each session highlights valuable OSF features and resources, covering topics from search and metadata to APIs and digital preservation. Attendees also receive a discount code for select self-paced training courses.

The next session, **How to Use FAIR Metadata** on **May 28**, explores how OSF metadata can help get your research out into the world. In preparation for this webinar, feel free to read through our [Metadata Help Guide](#).

Sign Up



OSF for Organizations

Every 6 weeks on Wednesday at 1 PM ET

Join COS for a monthly walkthrough of OSF's suite of paid products and services designed to help research organizations build and sustain open scholarship infrastructure. This webinar is intended for research librarians, data managers, data curators, open science coordinators, research support staff, VPR offices, and anyone exploring institutional support for open scholarship.

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